KHETHI IN TECH · STUDENT FIELD GUIDE

Your Tech Start

A calm, practical route from curious student to confident beginner.

You do not need a perfect plan.
Pick one direction, learn the foundations for free, make a small thing and show what you learned. Repeat until the next step is clearer.

A free-first guide for students in South Africa and beyond
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01 · PICK A DIRECTION

Choose the work, not the fanciest title

Tech is a collection of jobs. You can change direction as you discover what you enjoy. These are starting points, not boxes you must stay inside.

Build software

Make websites, applications and tools.

Try: HTML, CSS, JavaScript or Python, Git and testing.

Work with data

Find useful answers in information.

Try: spreadsheets, SQL, Python, charts and data cleaning.

Protect systems

Help people and organisations reduce security risk.

Try: networking, Linux, safe labs and clear security notes.

Make systems run

Deploy and maintain services and infrastructure.

Try: Linux, networking, scripting, containers and cloud basics.

Ask yourself

- Would I rather create a screen, investigate a pattern, solve a security puzzle or keep a service reliable?
- Which school subject, hobby or everyday problem makes me curious?
- What can I try for two weeks before I decide whether I like it?

Try this: choose one role to explore for a month. You are testing an interest, not signing a lifelong contract.

Explore local training options through WeThinkCode_ at https://wethinkcode.co.za/ and South African youth openings at https://sayouth.mobi/. Confirm current requirements and dates on each official site.

Make progress in twelve weeks

Aim for three to five focused hours a week. If exams or life get busy, keep one small weekly session. Consistency beats a heroic weekend followed by a three-month disappearance.

Weeks 1 to 2	**Choose one learning path.** Set up a folder, create a GitHub account if you can, and learn basic file and terminal navigation.
Weeks 3 to 4	**Learn core concepts.** Follow one beginner course. Take notes in your own words. Do the exercises yourself before peeking at solutions.
Weeks 5 to 6	**Build a tiny project.** Pick a problem you care about. Make the first version small enough to finish in a week.
Weeks 7 to 8	**Improve it.** Add one feature, tests or accessibility improvements. Ask a classmate, mentor or teacher to try it.
Weeks 9 to 10	**Explain the work.** Write a README with the goal, setup, features, tools and lessons learned. Add screenshots only if they help.
Weeks 11 to 12	**Show it and choose again.** Share the project, update your CV and decide whether to continue this path or explore another.

Free course starts

freeCodeCamp: https://www.freecodecamp.org/learn/

CS50: https://cs50.harvard.edu/

Microsoft Learn: https://learn.microsoft.com/training/

Free references

MDN: https://developer.mozilla.org/

Python: https://docs.python.org/3/tutorial/

Git: https://git-scm.com/book/en/v2

Course platforms change access and certificate terms. A free lesson may have a paid exam, certificate, lab or subscription. Check the specific course before enrolling.

03 · BUILD SOMETHING REAL

One small project can teach a lot

A project does not need artificial intelligence, blockchain and a launch party. It needs a clear purpose and a finished first version.

Web developer

Make a mobile-friendly page for a club, student society or local service. Add accessible navigation and a contact route.

Data learner

Use a public dataset to answer one question. Explain how you cleaned it and show a simple chart with a useful caption.

Security learner

Write a checklist for account safety or explain a finding from an intentionally vulnerable practice lab. Test only with permission.

Cloud learner

Publish a static page, write down the steps, set a budget alert if a cloud account is involved and remove resources when done.

Your project README

1. **Purpose:** Who is this for, and what can they do?
2. **Build:** What works, which tools did you use, and how can someone try it?
3. **Learning:** What surprised you, and what are the limits?
4. **Next:** What would you improve with more time?

> **Portfolio rule:** label team work honestly. Say what you made, what someone else made and which parts you can explain.

Before you publish

- ☐ No passwords, access tokens or private keys in the repository
- ☐ No private student data in screenshots or sample files
- ☐ Every external source is credited or linked
- ☐ The project opens on a phone and with a keyboard

A simple student application kit

You do not have to apply everywhere. Keep a small record, check the official requirements and make each application clear.

One-page student CV outline

Name and contact: professional email, location and portfolio link.

Short profile: what you are learning, the kind of opportunity you want and one strength you can support with evidence.

Education: school or programme, dates and relevant subjects or modules.

Projects: two or three examples with your contribution, tools and a link.

Skills: list tools you have actually used. Mark coursework or learning in progress clearly.

Experience: include school, volunteering, family or community responsibilities when they show relevant skills. Do not invent work experience.

Weekly opportunity routine

1. Choose one afternoon to check a school, academy, bursary or internship source.
2. Save the organisation, official link, deadline, requirements and next action.
3. Ask a trusted person to review important applications.
4. Keep copies of your CV and project links in one folder.
5. Follow up politely if the organisation says that is welcome.

Pause if: someone asks you to pay a surprise recruitment fee, share a password or send sensitive documents through an unverified account. Find the official contact details yourself and confirm the request.

South African student funding information: https://www.nsfas.org.za/. Current youth opportunities: https://sayouth.mobi/. These are starting points; read each active programme's eligibility rules.

05 · YOUR NEXT SMALL STEP

Keep the loop going

A career grows through repeated practice, support and useful feedback. Make the next task small enough to begin this week.

My plan

I want to explore this role:

One free resource I will use:

A tiny project I can finish:

Someone I can ask for feedback:

My first 30-minute action:

Progress scoreboard

- ☐ I practised this week
- ☐ I wrote down one question and found an answer
- ☐ I made or improved one small thing
- ☐ I asked for or acted on feedback
- ☐ I took a break when I needed one

A reminder: you are allowed to be a beginner. Your first project is proof that you started, not a final exam for your entire future.

Created by Khethi in Tech. Free learning guide, October 2026. Course and opportunity information may change. Check provider terms before committing time or money.

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